# porches in the sky

**The fire escape has the paradoxical quality of being intensely private and public at once. It belongs to a particular apartment, but projects outward from the building and into the street.**

**It is reached from the interior of a home, yet exposed to the city.**

**From behind a window, it is an extension of private life. From the sidewalk, it becomes part of the public façade.**

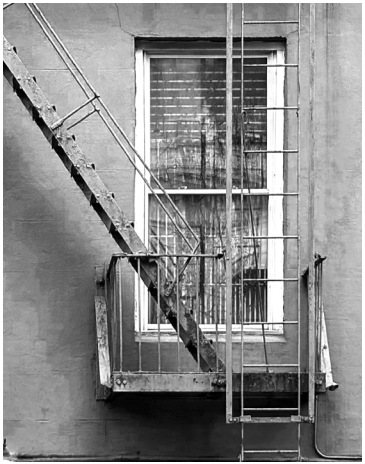
**Its original purpose was straightforward: to provide a way out in an emergency. But from the beginning, the fire escape acquired uses that had little to do with evacuation.**

**The space was too valuable to be reserved only for catastrophe.**

**In the summer, when tenement interiors became unbearable, fire escapes offered an unexpected form of relief. People slept outside, drank coffee, talked with neighbors, watched the street, stored belongings, grew plants, and allowed children to play. Families occupied separate levels of the same façade.**

**The fire escape became an extra room, although it was a room without walls or a ceiling. It could offer the privacy of stepping away from a crowded apartment while remaining completely exposed to everything happening beyond it.**

**It was somewhere to disappear for air or conversation, but also somewhere to watch the city, participate in its activity, and be seen by others doing the same. This made the fire escape a peculiar form of urban space.**



**It was not quite a balcony, not quite a porch, not quite a corridor, and not quite a street. It was a private territory projected into public space.**

**One could retreat from the apartment without withdrawing from the city. Its existence was also part of a larger idea about how New York should function as a collective place.**

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**The laws that required fire escapes were ultimately concerned with the protection of the city's residents, including those living in its poorest buildings. The fire escape therefore became more than a piece of safety infrastructure.**

**It represented a small right to space within an extremely dense city: a piece of the exterior attached to a private home, but shared visually with everyone around it.**

**Over time, many of the activities once associated with these spaces disappeared. Air conditioning, refrigeration, changing building regulations, concerns about security, and changing patterns of city life altered what happened on the fire escape.**

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**The rooms are still there,
suspended outside the windows.**

**It is a room outside a room.**

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Fifty photographs of fire escapes in the East Village, New York.
Text adapted from Adrian Coleman, Proletarian Terrace, Columbia GSAPP, 2012.